Serving While Waiting

What do you do while you’re waiting? Wait on the Lord in prayer, and wait for the Lord in work — the Word must run, and idleness must not become meddling.

Where this study fits

2 Thessalonians · seven studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–2
Introduction and Background

02 1:3–12
Paul's Admiration for the Thessalonians

03 2:1–5
Confusion Concerning the Coming

04 2:6–12
The Removal of the Restrainer

05 2:13–17
The Day of the Lord and Believers

06 3:1–12
Serving While Waiting

07 3:13–18
My Brother's Keeper

Grace and peace frame the letter (1:2; 3:16–18): persecution in chapter 1, prophecy in chapter 2, correction in chapter 3.

Wait on the Lord — wait for the Lord

2 Thessalonians 3:1–12 · Outline I–II

I · Wait on the Lord · 3:1–5

- The content of the prayer — ministry and misery
- The confidence of the prayer — the Lord is faithful
- The consequences of the prayer — love and patience

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II · Wait for the Lord · 3:6–12

- The exhortation — withdraw
- The example — Paul’s own work
- The explanation — busybodies
- The solution — work in quietness

Trust and obey: “Fear God and keep His commandments” (Eccl 12:13) — pray and trust; work and obey.

“Pray for us”

2 Thessalonians 3:1–2 · I.A — The content of the prayer

Their ministry · v.1

τρέχω run swiftly · G5143

- That the Word may run — it has no feet
- And be glorified — believed, prized
- “Just as it is with you”

Their misery · v.2

ἄτοπος · πονηρός out of place · harmful

- Deliverance from unreasonable, wicked men
- “For not all have faith”
- They oppose the gift and the giver

Satan doesn’t bother those who don’t bother him. Let’s start bothering Satan — and that will be giving the Word.

“But the Lord is faithful”

2 Thessalonians 3:3–4 · I.B — The confidence of the prayer

A

He will establish you

Strengthened in the faith as you study His Book

v.3a

B

He will guard you

From the evil one — and from evil

φυλάσσω · πονηρός · v.3b

C

You will do

What you are doing — and continue

v.4

pistis → pistos: “not all have faith … but the Lord is faithful” (3:2–3)

Ryrie: could you stop at an accident and lead a dying man to the Lord? Know the faith — and stand in it.

Into God’s love and Christ’s patience

2 Thessalonians 3:5 · I.C — The consequences of the prayer

The love of God · 5a

κατευθύνω direct · G2720

- “God so loved the world”
- Love for the unlovely
- Even unlovely Christians

The patience of Christ · 5b

1. **Philip — John 14:8–9**
   “Have I been with you so long, and you still don’t know?”

2. **James and John**
   The Sons of Thunder: “Shall we call down fire?”

3. **Peter — Matthew 16**
   From a revelation from heaven to “Get behind Me, Satan!”

God’s love to love people, and Christ’s patience to work with them — until the good news gets passed on.

Exhortation and example

2 Thessalonians 3:6–10 · II.A–B — Wait for the Lord

A **The order · v.6**

Withdraw from the brother who walks disorderly (στέλλω · ἀτάκτως)

B **Integrity · v.7**

“Do as I do, because I do as I say” (μιμέομαι)

C **Industry · v.8**

Night and day — no one’s bread free of charge

D **Intention · v.9**

He had the right (ἐξουσία) — and laid it aside as an example

E **Intimation · v.10**

“If anyone will not work, neither shall he eat”

! **“Forgive me this wrong!”**

Paul to Corinth: his one “fault” — he was no burden (2 Cor 12:13)

Not busy at work — busybodies

2 Thessalonians 3:11–12 · II.C–D — The explanation and the solution

The problem · v.11
περιεργάζομαι busybodies · G4020

- Able to work — but would not
- Spare time turned into meddling
- Interrupting those who were working

vs

The solution · v.12
ἡσυχία quietness · G2271

- Work in quietness
- Eat your own bread
- Said in person, in 1 Thess 4:11, and here

“Eat what’s put before you, and let it stop your mouth.” — the teacher’s mother, to six children in the Depression

Discuss and apply

2 Thessalonians 3:1–12 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. What does it mean for the Word to “run” and to be “glorified,” and how can we help it run where we cannot go?

2. What was the real problem with those who would not work, and how did Paul’s example answer it?

Apply

Put Legs Under Your Prayers
Choose one missionary your church supports and pray for them by name every day this week.

Work Quietly While You Wait
When tempted to comment on someone else’s affairs, turn that moment into a prayer for them instead.

In one line: While we wait: pray that the Word runs, trust the faithful Lord, and work quietly — trust and obey.